

# POSC 459: Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Fall 2026

## Faculty Information

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**Office Hours:** Mondays and Wednesdays, [TBD], and by [appointment](#).

**Schedule meetings:** [dadams.io/appointments](http://dadams.io/appointments)

## Course Communication

All course announcements and communications will be sent via *Canvas* and university email. Students are responsible for regularly checking their *Canvas* notifications and email, and for ensuring that Canvas notifications are set to receive course messages. Students are expected to check *Canvas* and their email at least once daily.

**Response time:** I will strive to respond to all student emails and *Canvas* messages within 24 hours, except on weekends and holidays. If you have not received a response within 24 hours, please send a follow-up message. If you are still waiting after 48 hours, contact me via phone or SMS at (657) 278-4770.

## Technical Problems

If you encounter any technical difficulties, contact the instructor immediately to document the problem. Then contact: [student IT help desk](#), [email](#), phone (657) 278-8888, walk-in [student genius center](#), or online chat via the [portal](#) (“Online IT Help” then “Live Chat”).

**For issues with Canvas:** Canvas Support Hotline = (657) 278-8888, [search the CSUF Canvas Guides](#), or [report a problem](#).

**Alternative submission:** If you cannot submit an assignment via *Canvas*, contact the professor as soon as possible to document the issue and arrange an alternative.

## Course Information

**Prefix, number, title:** POSC 459, *Social Welfare Politics and Policy*

**Meeting times:** In-Person, Monday & Wednesday, 1:00–2:15 p.m., [Room TBD]

**Units:** 3    **Schedule Code:** [TBD]

**Course requisite(s):** POSC 100 or graduate standing

**Catalog description:** American social policies—welfare, Social Security, health care—and the political environment in which they exist. Origins, implementation, and reforms of current social policies, emphasizing questions of effectiveness and policy improvement.

**Policy regarding the use of generative AI:** See the *Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology* section below.

**Course materials and equipment:** Canvas; access to course readings; laptop recommended

**Required texts:** Howard (2007); Campbell (2014); Desmond (2023); plus ebook readings through Pollak Library (see *Required Texts* below)

## Course Description

This course is an intensive introduction to U.S. social welfare policy and politics. It has four parts: the big picture (who are the poor, and how did the welfare state develop?); the programs (social insurance, the safety net, tax expenditures); two case studies in major reform (welfare reform and the ACA); and the political forces that shape all of it (public opinion, interest groups, race, and gender).

The course moves between levels of analysis. Comparative welfare state theory sits alongside individual family narratives; legislative history sits alongside street-level program design. Both matter. You cannot understand why TANF looks the way it does without understanding the politics that produced it, and you cannot evaluate whether the ACA succeeded without understanding what it was actually trying to accomplish.

This course is taught from a political science and policy analysis perspective. Political science helps explain *why* we get the policies we get; policy analysis helps evaluate *whether those policies do what they claim*. Both lenses are at work throughout the semester.

## Student Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

1. Describe the core architecture of the U.S. welfare state: social insurance, public assistance, tax expenditures, and public-private arrangements.
2. Trace the political development of major programs (Social Security, TANF, Medicaid, ACA) and connect that history to current policy debates.
3. Apply key concepts from political science and policy analysis to evaluate welfare programs: policy feedback, institutional design, interest group politics, and public opinion.
4. Analyze how race and gender have structured both program design and access to benefits.
5. Situate U.S. welfare policy within a comparative frame and explain the sources of American exceptionalism.
6. Construct an evidence-based policy argument using primary sources and scholarly literature.

## Required Texts

The following are available for purchase at the Titan bookstore:

1. Howard, Christopher. 2007. *The Welfare State Nobody Knows: Debunking Myths About U.S. Social Policy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
2. Campbell, Andrea Louise. 2014. *Trapped in America's Safety Net: One Family's Struggle*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
3. Desmond, Matthew. 2023. *Poverty, by America*. New York, NY: Crown.

## Required Texts Available as Ebooks at Pollak Library

1. Rank, Mark Robert, Lawrence M. Eppard, and Heather E. Bullock. 2021. *Poorly Understood: What America Gets Wrong About Poverty*. Oxford University Press.  
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=6461413>
2. Howard, Christopher. 2022. *Who Cares: The Social Safety Net in America*. Oxford University Press.  
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?pq-origsite=primo&docID=7099798>
3. Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. 2016. *Healthcare Reform and American Politics: What Everyone Needs to Know*, 3rd ed. Oxford University Press.  
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=4310736>
4. Beland, David, Kimberly J. Morgan, and Christopher Howard, eds. 2015. *The Oxford Handbook of U.S. Social Policy*. Oxford University Press.  
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=1825907>
5. Mettler, Suzanne. 2018. *Dividing Citizens: Gender and Federalism in New Deal Public Policy*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press. Search the Pollak Library catalog by title; the 2018 electronic edition is the one to use. (*Week 13.*)

## Additional Readings

Additional readings—articles, book chapters, policy documents, and documentary viewing guides—are posted on Canvas and noted in the course schedule. Canvas readings are required and carry equal weight to book readings.

## Student Resources Website

It is the student's responsibility to read and understand the required and important [student information for course syllabi](#). Included is information about:

- University learning goals and General Education learning objectives
- Students' rights to accommodations
- Campus student support resources and academic integrity

- Emergency preparedness; library and IT services
- Software privacy, accessibility statement, diversity statement, and land acknowledgement
- Final exam schedule and semester calendar

## Course Requirements

### Course Format

This is an in-person lecture and discussion course meeting twice weekly for 75 minutes. Students complete assigned readings before class; class time is divided between lecture, structured discussion, and periodic documentary screenings. Three weeks are structured as asynchronous work weeks with no in-person meetings (see below).

### Three Asynchronous Weeks

Three weeks are designated asynchronous. There are no in-person meetings those weeks. Students complete assigned readings, watch a designated documentary, and submit a Canvas response by that Friday at 11:59 p.m. Specific instructions will be posted to Canvas in advance.

- **Week 4 (Async):** Political development of the welfare state; *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2
- **Week 9 (Async):** Welfare reform; *Two American Families*
- **Week 14 (Async):** Public opinion and interest groups; term papers and grad outlines due

### Graded Work

- **Required for all students (60% total):** Attendance and Participation (10%); Discussion Papers, 5 of 10 (10%); Midterm Exam (20%); Final Exam (20%).
- **Undergraduates only (40% total):**

- **Policy Brief (20%):** A 3–4 page analysis of one program: OASDI, SSI, TANF, Unemployment Insurance, Medicaid, Medicare, SNAP, or the EITC. Cover the program's stated purpose, who it serves, its major design features, and one significant reform debate. Academic writing conventions and source citations required.
- **Term Paper (20%):** A 6–8 page research paper building on the policy brief. Analyze the political and policy-relevant strengths and weaknesses of your program and develop a reform proposal, drawing on course concepts and the program's political history.
- **Graduate students only (40% total):**
  - **Research Proposal (10%):** Topic, research question, and preliminary bibliography.
  - **Introduction/Outline/Annotated Bibliography (10%):** Substantial revision from the proposal with clear research design and sources.
  - **Final Research Paper (20%):** A 10–15 page original research paper submitted during finals week.

## Graduate Student Requirements

Graduate students complete all readings including graduate-only readings posted on Canvas. They take both the midterm and final exams and write five discussion papers. In place of the undergraduate policy brief and term paper, graduate students complete a scaffolded 10–15 page original research paper sequence with staged feedback and revision across three milestones:

1. **Research Proposal (10%)** (1–2 pages): Due Week 7, October 5.
  - Identify policy topic, core research question, and why the question matters for welfare politics/policy.
  - Include a working thesis or argument direction.
  - Include a preliminary bibliography (minimum 6 credible sources, including scholarly sources).
  - Instructor feedback will focus on scope, feasibility, and argument focus.
2. **Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography (10%):** Due Week 14, December 2.

- Revised introduction with clear thesis and paper roadmap.
- Detailed section outline showing claim flow and supporting evidence for each section.
- Annotated bibliography with brief annotations describing each source's argument and relevance to your project.
- Substantial revision from the proposal is expected; this milestone should show a sharpened question and stronger evidence base.

**3. Final Research Paper (20%) (10–15 pages):** Due during finals week.

- Original analysis that synthesizes course concepts, scholarly literature, and policy evidence.
- Clear argument structure (thesis, evidence, analysis, counterargument/limitations, conclusion).
- Proper citation and academic writing conventions.
- The final submission should directly incorporate and respond to feedback from Milestones 1 and 2.

## Grading Policies and Standards

**a. Grading scale:** See Table 1 for the full letter-grade percentage scale used in this course.

| Table 1: Grade scale |            |       |           |
|----------------------|------------|-------|-----------|
| Grade                | Percent    | Grade | Percent   |
| A+                   | 98.0–100.0 | C+    | 77.0–79.9 |
| A                    | 93.0–97.9  | C     | 73.0–76.9 |
| A-                   | 90.0–92.9  | C-    | 70.0–72.9 |
| B+                   | 87.0–89.9  | D+    | 67.0–69.9 |
| B                    | 83.0–86.9  | D     | 63.0–66.9 |
| B-                   | 80.0–82.9  | D-    | 60.0–62.9 |
|                      |            | F     | 0.0–59.9  |

**b. Required course assignments (undergraduate):** See Table 2 for undergraduate assignment weights and due dates.

Table 2: Undergraduate assignment weighting

| Assignment                   | Weight      | Due                   |
|------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------|
| Attendance and Participation | 10%         | Ongoing               |
| Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)   | 10%         | See schedule          |
| Midterm Exam                 | 20%         | Wednesday, October 14 |
| Policy Brief                 | 20%         | Wednesday, October 28 |
| Term Paper                   | 20%         | Wednesday, December 2 |
| Final Exam                   | 20%         | Finals Week           |
| <b>Total</b>                 | <b>100%</b> |                       |

Table 3: Graduate assignment weighting

| Assignment                                        | Weight      | Due                   |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------|
| Attendance and Participation                      | 10%         | Ongoing               |
| Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)                        | 10%         | See schedule          |
| Midterm Exam                                      | 20%         | Wednesday, October 14 |
| Research Proposal                                 | 10%         | Monday, October 5     |
| Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography | 10%         | Wednesday, December 2 |
| Final Research Paper                              | 20%         | Finals Week           |
| Final Exam                                        | 20%         | Finals Week           |
| <b>Total</b>                                      | <b>100%</b> |                       |

See Table 3 for graduate assignment weights and due dates.

**c. Attendance and participation policy:** Students are expected to attend all in-person sessions. If you are unable to attend, notify the professor in advance. You are responsible for obtaining any materials or information covered during absences. Participation in in-class activities cannot be made up.

**Reading journal.** Part of your participation grade is a running reading journal: **ten entries** across the semester logging connections, surprises, and reform-relevant observations from the readings. I check it twice, on **October 14** and **December 9**. **What counts is the entry, not where you wrote it.** The Idea Catcher module is the easiest place to keep one and I recommend it, but a text file, a notebook, or a Canvas page all count the same.

**d. Examination dates:**

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Final Exam: Finals week; exact date and time assigned by Registrar (December 14–18)



**e. Make-up and late submission policy:** All assignments are due on the date specified in the course schedule. Extensions must be requested in writing before the due date and will be granted only for illness or other documented unforeseen circumstances. Late work without an approved extension loses one-third of a letter grade per calendar day.

**Alternative procedures for submitting work:** Students are expected to submit all written work via *Canvas*. Exams are taken in person. If you cannot submit via *Canvas*, contact the professor immediately to arrange an alternative.

**f. Authentication of student work:** Students may be required to submit their work to a plagiarism detection service. Cal State Fullerton uses Turnitin©. Students should be aware that submitted work may be checked for authenticity and originality.

**g. Extra credit:** There are no extra credit assignments in this course.

**h. Retention of student work:** Work submitted for a grade, whether as a hard copy or through Canvas, shall be retained for a reasonable time after the semester ends, not to exceed the last day of the subsequent semester. Students have the right to review graded work in the presence of the instructor. (UPS 320.005)

## Academic Integrity

Students are expected to adhere to the highest standards of academic integrity. Any student found to have engaged in academic dishonesty will be subject to the sanctions described in the [Academic Dishonesty Policy](#) (UPS 300.021). Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, fabrication, facilitating academic dishonesty, and submitting previously graded work without prior authorization. Students are expected to be familiar with the university's policy and to adhere to it in all aspects of this course.

## Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology

Generative AI is permitted in this course, but use must be transparent, intentional, and in service of learning. The core principle is simple: **you must do the intellectual work of this course**. AI can amplify your thinking, but not replace it.

**Short version:** if a tool suggests new words and you use them, that counts as AI use under this policy. Everything below is detail.

## What counts as generative AI

For this course, generative AI means any system that produces or suggests human-like text, images, data analysis, or other content—**whether you asked for it or it appeared on its own**. This includes:

- Large language models (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, TitanGPT, and any successor products)
- Text-to-image and multimodal generators (DALL-E, Midjourney, and equivalents)
- AI writing assistants and summarizers
- Automated coding, data, and content generators

**AI built into tools you already use.** This is the part people miss. The policy also covers AI features embedded in ordinary software: Google Docs Smart Compose and “Help me write,” Gmail Smart Reply, Microsoft Word Copilot, Apple Intelligence and other phone or operating-system writing assistants, Google and Bing AI search summaries, and PDF readers or reference managers that summarize sources or answer questions about them. **You do not have to feel like you “used AI” for it to count.**

## Basic mechanics versus generative assistance

Always fine, and never needs disclosure: spellcheck, punctuation correction, dictionary and thesaurus lookup, grammar flags.

Covered by this policy: sentence rewriting, paraphrasing, summarizing, tone or style shifting, drafting, generating analysis.

**The test, for tools that do both.** Most tools now flag *and* offer to fix. The distinction is what the tool hands you: if it only flags a possible problem, that is basic mechanics. If it proposes new wording, a summary, or a rewritten version for you to adopt, this policy covers it. A squiggly underline is a flag; a suggested replacement sentence is generative—even inside a spellchecker or grammar tool. Grammarly is the common case: its spelling and punctuation corrections are basic mechanics; its rewriting, paraphrasing, and “sound more professional” features are not.

**What you can use freely, and where to go instead.** Ordinary spelling, grammar, and punctuation checking is always fine and never needs disclosure. **Microsoft Word’s built-in spelling and grammar checker, LanguageTool, and equivalents are all permitted,**

and so is the flagging half of Grammarly. The line is the same one as above: a tool that tells you something may be wrong is fine; a tool that writes the replacement is not.

If what you actually want is help making your writing *sound better*—and that is a completely reasonable thing to want, particularly if you have been told your whole life that your writing is too casual or not academic enough—the honest answer is that a rewrite button does not teach you to do it yourself, and it is the part of your writing this course is trying to develop. **The CSUF Writing Center** (Pollak Library North 199, in person and online, free, appointments and drop-in) does the same job in a way that leaves the skill with you. I will also read a draft paragraph and tell you what is making it land flat. Neither of those requires disclosing anything, and neither costs you points.

**Features you did not turn on.** Some software has AI switched on by default. **Its presence is not a violation. Adopting its output is.** If your word processor suggests the rest of your sentence and you accept it, that is use; if it suggests and you ignore it, nothing has happened. You are responsible for what you accept, not for what a company enabled without asking you. Turning these features off is worth doing—it removes the temptation and the ambiguity at once—and I am happy to show you how.

**On edge cases.** AI is now embedded in enough ordinary software that neither of us will anticipate every case. If you are unsure whether something counts, **ask before you submit.** A good-faith question asked in advance is treated as exactly that—it is not a confession and it does not put you under suspicion.

## Where AI fits: assignment labels

Every assignment in this course carries one of three labels, stated on the assignment itself. You should never have to infer it.

- **GREEN** — AI use permitted, within the course-wide limits below. No disclosure needed. Green is not blanket permission: the “not permitted” list applies to every assignment, on every label.
- **YELLOW** — Permitted within stated limits, plus the course-wide limits. **Disclosure required.** The assignment says what is in bounds.
- **RED** — No AI. The assignment is designed to be completed without it, and doing so is the point.

**Red assignments in this course:** the Week 2 baseline writing diagnostic, all in-class writing, the midterm exam, and the final exam. Everything else is Green or Yellow, and here is the whole list, so you are not waiting for a Canvas page to open to find out.

| <b>Assignment</b>                             | <b>Label</b> | <b>Who</b>    |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------|---------------|
| Reading journal (ten entries, participation)  | GREEN        | All           |
| Week 2 baseline writing diagnostic            | RED          | All           |
| All in-class writing and in-class activities  | RED          | All           |
| Midterm exam                                  | RED          | All           |
| Final exam                                    | RED          | All           |
| Discussion papers (5 of 10)                   | YELLOW       | All           |
| Documentary responses (async weeks)           | YELLOW       | All           |
| Policy brief: program selection               | YELLOW       | Undergraduate |
| Policy brief: source and claims memo          | YELLOW       | Undergraduate |
| Policy brief                                  | YELLOW       | Undergraduate |
| Term paper                                    | YELLOW       | Undergraduate |
| Research proposal                             | YELLOW       | Graduate      |
| Introduction, outline, annotated bibliography | YELLOW       | Graduate      |
| Final research paper                          | YELLOW       | Graduate      |

The label also appears on each assignment sheet. If the two ever disagree, tell me and use this table until I fix it.

**If an assignment has no label**, treat it as Yellow and ask me before using anything beyond basic mechanics. An unlabeled assignment is my oversight, not an opening.

Red assignments are not punishments or trust tests. Some capacities only develop when you build them yourself, and I need to see your unaided thinking at least once to be useful to you for the rest of the term.

## **Course-supported AI environment: PapyrusAI**

This course uses **PapyrusAI** ([genaied.org/papyrusai](https://genaied.org/papyrusai)) as the supported AI environment for graded writing. PapyrusAI is an instructor-configured, contained LLM environment: I

build the modules, set the source materials the AI may draw on, and define how it interacts with you. Modules in this course are designed to *coach*, not to write for you—they will ask questions, push back on weak claims, and point you to readings, but they will not produce paragraphs you can paste into an assignment.

Specific PapyrusAI modules accompany the reading journal, the policy brief, the term paper, and the graduate research milestones. **Access PapyrusAI from the left-hand navigation menu inside our Canvas course site.** There is no separate login and no password to remember. The first time you open it you will be asked for a course code; ours is **FALL2026-POSC459**. Enter it exactly as written—a mistyped code does not give you an error, it puts you somewhere that is not this class, and you will not see our modules. If PapyrusAI does not appear in the navigation menu, or the code does not work, tell me before you spend time working around it. Use of these modules is encouraged but not required; they exist to make productive AI use easy to access and unproductive use harder to fall into.

You may also use general-purpose AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, etc.) outside PapyrusAI subject to the rules below. The permitted/not-permitted list applies equally regardless of which tool you use.

**You can complete this entire course without PapyrusAI.** Every graded assignment is written to be done on a non-PapyrusAI path, and taking that path costs you nothing in points or standing. Where an assignment asks you to show that you talked your work through with someone, a module session, a CSUF Writing Center appointment, and a conversation with me all count equally. **Neither path is the default and neither is worth more.** You do not owe me a reason for your choice, and you can change it at any point in the semester. **If you switch in the middle of a multi-stage assignment, whatever you have already produced still counts and you do not redo any of it—**tell me you have switched and keep going.

**And if the tool is broken, that is not your problem to solve at midnight.** PapyrusAI is new, and some of you will hit a wrong code, a missing menu item, or a module that will not load. **The module is never the reason an assignment is late.** Email me with what happened, submit what you have, and we will sort it out. I would rather get that email at 11 p.m. than read an apology in week fourteen.

**About the research study.** PapyrusAI is being studied at CSUF under IRB protocol HSR-24-25-240, *Enhancing Academic Writing and Digital Literacy with an AI Coach*. You will hear about it in Week 2 and decide then whether to take part. Participation is voluntary, you may withdraw at any time, and declining puts you on the non-PapyrusAI path described

above—which is a complete path, not a reduced one. Nothing about that decision affects your grade, and I will not treat it as a statement about your work.

### **Permitted uses:**

- Brainstorming, and working out an outline with it before you have written the piece
- Explaining concepts you don't understand (then explaining it back in your own words). Concept explanation is permitted; uploading an assigned reading for the tool to summarize or explain is not, unless I explicitly allow it.
- Literature searching and locating sources, which you then read yourself
- Diagnosing problems in your clarity, grammar, or organization
- Sanity-checking your analysis or logic
- Generating synthetic examples or test cases for your ideas

**Where editing ends and rewriting begins.** This is the boundary students ask about most, so here it is plainly: **AI may identify problems in your writing. It may not supply the prose that fixes them.** “This paragraph buries its main claim” is fine—act on it yourself. “Here is a clearer version of your paragraph” is not, even if you edit it afterward. Asking *what is wrong* is permitted; asking it to *write the fix* is not.

**On outlines, since this is where the line looks blurry.** Thinking through an outline with a tool *before* you draft is permitted—that is planning, and the plan is still yours to argue for. Handing it a draft you have written and asking it to reorganize the piece is not, because at that point the structure is a finding about your argument and finding it is the work. The short version: plan with it, do not let it rearrange you.

### **Not permitted:**

- Using AI to generate your analysis, arguments, or conclusions
- Submitting AI-generated text as your own writing
- Using AI to avoid engaging with course concepts or readings
- Letting AI do the intellectual heavy lifting (interpreting sources, building arguments, synthesizing ideas)

## Baseline writing diagnostic:

During Week 2, you will complete a short in-class writing exercise (unaided, handwritten or in a locked-down Canvas window) responding to a course prompt. This is not graded for content and counts toward participation. Its purpose is to establish a baseline sample of your own writing voice early in the semester, before AI-supported assignments begin.

## Disclosure requirement:

On Yellow work, include a brief note at the end of the assignment: what tool, and what you used it for (e.g., “I used Claude to check whether my argument in Section 3 held together, and to find two CBO reports that I then read. All prose and all structure are mine.”). One or two sentences is the whole requirement. **You do not need to attach prompts, transcripts, or logs unless an assignment specifically asks for them—**and if one does, it will say so. For work completed inside a PapyrusAI module, you can download the conversation from its three-dot menu and attach that file instead of writing the sentence. **The download is a manual step. Nothing attaches on its own, and the vendor does not promise to retain your conversations indefinitely, so save what you will need at the end of a session rather than at the deadline.**

**This is not a confession.** It is a description of your process, the same way a methods section describes how a study was run. Disclosing use has never lowered a grade in my courses and it is not going to start. What creates a problem is undisclosed use that shows up in the work—and it does show up.

## Why this policy exists

You deserve reasons, not just rules.

**AI makes breadth cheap.** When summarizing a fifth reading costs nothing, you summarize the fifth reading instead of sitting with the second one until you understand what it is actually claiming. The tool quietly relocates your effort from understanding to coverage—and coverage is not what this course, or your career, rewards. This is not a claim that AI makes people lazy. It is a claim about where the path of least resistance leads when a genuinely useful tool is available.

**These systems are agreeable.** They will validate a weak thesis enthusiastically, produce fluent prose about things they have no basis for asserting, and fabricate citations that look exactly like real ones. Fluency is not accuracy. In a field where you will be asked to defend

claims about what programs do and whom they affect, a confident and compliant reader is worse than no reader at all—unless you are already doing the judging.

**And in this course specifically.** This policy supports Outcomes 3, 4, and 6 because you must practice those judgments without outsourcing them. You are asked to apply policy-analytic concepts to evaluate welfare programs (Outcome 3), to analyze how race and gender structured both program design and access to benefits (Outcome 4), and to construct evidence-based arguments from primary sources (Outcome 6). Every one of those is a judgment you have to make yourself.

There is a sharper problem here than in most courses. A model trained on the existing public conversation about welfare will reproduce the dominant American framing of it—deservingness distinctions, work-ethic moralism, the residue of the “welfare queen” narrative—because that framing saturates the text it learned from. That is precisely the set of assumptions this course exists to interrogate. Using such a tool uncritically does not just risk a weaker paper. It hands your analysis over to the thing you are supposed to be analyzing. We will look at this directly in an early-semester exercise, because it is a course concept as much as a technology caution.

## **Guidance: using these tools well**

- **Authorship.** All submitted prose is written by you. AI may critique; it may not generate or rewrite your sentences, paragraphs, or structure.
- **Verification.** Check every fact, quotation, and citation before it enters your work. Fabricated sources are the failure mode most likely to hurt you, and they are convincing.
- **Bias.** These systems reproduce the assumptions in their training data. Read outputs critically for whose perspective is centered and whose is missing—a skill this course is teaching you anyway.
- **Privacy and security.** Do not paste anything sensitive, private, or confidential into a chatbot: student records, personnel matters, unpublished data, or others’ personal information. Assume anything you enter may be retained *by the company*, indefinitely and beyond your reach. That is a separate question from whether *you* will still be able to open a past conversation in the product, which no vendor guarantees—which is why the advice below is to download anything you need at the end of a



session. Plan for both: it may outlive you wanting it, and it may vanish before you need it.

- **Do not feed it the course.** Unless I explicitly say otherwise, do not paste full assigned readings, a classmate's work, or confidential course materials into a public AI system. Much of what we read is licensed to the university, not to you to redistribute—and using AI to metabolize a reading you did not do is not a shortcut around the work, it *is* the work.
- **Sustainability.** These systems carry real energy and water costs. Thoughtful use is part of responsible use.
- **Opting out is legitimate.** If you would rather not use AI at all—for labor, environmental, privacy, or any other principled reason—that is a respected choice here. The PapyrusAI modules are genuinely optional, and no part of your grade depends on using them. If a required activity is a problem for you, come talk to me and we will find an alternative.

Further reading: [CSU AI Commons—Ethical and Responsible Use of AI for Students](#).

## When the policy is broken

**Misuse includes** submitting AI-generated or AI-rewritten prose as your own; using AI on a Red assignment; failing to disclose on Yellow work; and submitting fabricated citations or facts you did not verify.

**Consequences**, proportionate to what happened: a conversation and a revision requirement; a grade penalty; or, for serious or repeated violations, a formal referral under CSUF's Academic Dishonesty Policy (UPS 300.021), which can carry sanctions up to dismissal.

**How I judge severity.** These are not all the same thing and I will not treat them as if they were. I weigh the nature of the assignment; whether the use replaced core intellectual work or sat at the margins of it; **whether the problem was non-disclosure or substantive substitution**; and whether it is a first occurrence or a repeated one. Forgetting a disclosure sentence on otherwise honest work is an omission. Passing off generated analysis as your own is deception. They land in very different places.

**On detection.** I am not going to pretend I can catch everything with software, and **I will not run your writing through an AI detector and treat the output as evidence**. Those tools are unreliable, and their errors are not evenly distributed—they flag multilingual writers and

plain prose at higher rates. Making accusations on that basis would be both unfair and bad reasoning, and I teach you not to reason that way. What I will do is read carefully, ask you to explain your process, and make judgments based on the work, the assignment rules, and that conversation. *Walk me through how you got here.* If you did the thinking, that is an easy conversation and often a good one. If you did not, it is not. That is the actual standard, and it does not depend on which tool produced the prose.

## How AI use is assessed

AI use is evaluated by boundaries and learning, not polish: whether assignment-level rules were followed (Red assignments stayed Red); the quality of disclosure where required; whether the final work shows original analysis and a consistent authorial voice; and whether you can explain and defend your argument, evidence, and revisions without external support. If you cannot defend the work, it does not count as yours—regardless of how it was produced.

## Revisiting this policy

This policy is a working document, not a settled one. AI is embedded in enough ordinary software that good-faith students will hit cases neither of us anticipated. **We will take a few minutes at several points in the term to revisit this policy and work through edge cases that have actually come up.** Bring them—a case you are unsure about is more useful to the class than a rule I wrote in August.

And a standing invitation, which I mean: this is a course about how rules get made, whom they burden, and whether they accomplish what they claim. That includes this rule. If you think this policy is poorly designed, imposes burden it does not justify, or fails on its own terms, say so—in class or to me directly. I would rather hear it in week three than read it in evaluations.

## Technical Competencies

Students need:

- Proficiency with Canvas, including submitting assignments and accessing course materials
- Ability to use university email and Canvas messages for course communication

- Basic word processing skills and ability to export documents to PDF

## Calendar of Topics / Schedule of Classes

We will follow the schedule below as closely as possible. If adjustments are needed, you will receive advance notice in class and on *Canvas*.

**Key:** (Pollak) = Pollak Library eBook **Reading structure:** Core Readings are required. Recommended Readings are optional but encouraged. Grad Extension Readings are required for graduate students.

### Important dates:

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Graduate Research Proposals due: Monday, October 5
- Policy Briefs due (undergraduates): Wednesday, October 28
- Term Papers / Graduate Outlines due: Wednesday, December 2
- Final Exam: Finals week, December 14–18 (Registrar-assigned)
- Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27 (no class)
- Async Weeks: Week 4 (Sep 14–16), Week 9 (Oct 19–21), Week 14 (Nov 30–Dec 2)

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## PART I: The Big Picture

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### 8/24 – Week 1: Introduction — What Is the American Welfare State?

#### Readings

- Campbell, chapters 1–2: “Trying to Make it in America” & “Down the Rabbit Hole”
- Desmond, chapter 1: “The Kind of Problem Poverty Is”

## Film (assigned for async viewing; Canvas response due Friday 8/28)

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 1 (PBS Frontline, 2020, 54 min.)  
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/growing-up-poor-in-america/>

## Term paper / research paper introduction

- Overview of the semester writing arc: undergraduates produce a policy brief (Week 10) building into a term paper (Week 14); graduate students produce a research proposal (Week 7), outline (Week 14), and final paper (finals week). Begin collecting reform-relevant observations from this week onward—race, gender, public opinion, and political-feedback themes recur throughout the course and matter for the paper.

## PapyrusAI module

- **Idea Catcher** (open from Week 1, runs all semester). A lightweight journaling module where you log connections, surprises, and reform-relevant observations as you read. It is one convenient place to keep the reading journal that counts toward participation—the ten entries are what count, not the module. It will not write your paper. It will help you not arrive at Week 10 with a blank page.

## 9/1 – Week 2: Why Are So Many Americans Poor?

### Readings

- Howard, chapter 2: “Tracks of My Tiers”
- Desmond, chapter 2: “Why Haven’t We Made More Progress?”
- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section 1: “Who Are the Poor?” pp. 15–49 (Pollak)

### In-class activity

- **Baseline writing diagnostic** (Wednesday September 3, in-class, ~20 min, un-aided). Short response to a course prompt; not graded for content, counts toward participation. See AI policy for purpose.

## 9/7 – Week 3: American Exceptionalism?

*Monday September 7 is Labor Day — no class. Wednesday September 9 only.*

## Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 1: “She So Unusual”
- Desmond, chapters 3–4: “How We Undercut Workers” & “How We Force the Poor to Pay More”

## Grad Extension Readings

- Esping-Andersen, Gosta. 1990. *The Three Worlds of Welfare Capitalism*, chapter 1: “The Three Political Economies of the Welfare State,” pp. 9–34 (posted on Canvas)
- Hacker, Jacob S. 2004. “Privatizing Risk without Privatizing the Welfare State.” *APSR* 98(2): 243–260

## 9/14 – Week 4: ASYNC — Political Development of the Welfare State

*No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, September 18. Canvas response due Friday 11:59 p.m.*

## Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 3: “Twice in a Lifetime”
- Pierson, Paul. 1993. “When Effect Becomes Cause: Policy Feedback and Political Change.” *World Politics* 45(4): 595–628 (posted on Canvas)

## Grad Extension Readings

- Baumgartner, Frank and Bryan Jones. 2009. *Agendas and Instability in American Politics*, 2nd ed., chapters 1–3

## Film

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2 (PBS Frontline, 2021, 54 min.)

## PapyrusAI module

- **Documentary Companion (Async I).** Pairs the film with Pierson and Howard ch. 3; prompts your own observations before generating the Canvas response prompt. Optional, encouraged.

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## PART II: Programs of the Welfare State

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### 9/21 – Week 5: Social Security and Medicare

#### Readings

- Berkowitz, Edward D. and Larry DeWitt. “Social Security,” chapter 15 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Oberlander, Jonathan. “Medicare,” chapter 17 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Greszler, Rachel. 2021. “Seven Hard Truths Americans Should Know about Social Security.” Heritage Foundation Issue Brief 5212
- Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. 2018. “Top Ten Facts about Social Security”

#### Assignments

- Policy brief topic selection due Monday September 21 (brief Canvas post)

## PapyrusAI module

- **Policy Brief Scaffold** unlocks after topic selection. Per-program modules (OASDI, SSI, TANF, UI, Medicaid, Medicare, SNAP, EITC) walk you through stated purpose, beneficiaries, design features, and reform debate. Module asks questions; you write the brief.

## 9/28 – Week 6: The Safety Net, Part 1 — TANF, SNAP, and the EITC

### Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 5: “Programs for the Poor are not Always Poor Programs”
- Campbell, chapter 3: “The Place of the Poor in the American Welfare State”
- Desmond, chapter 5: “How We Rely on Welfare”
- Gitterman, Daniel. “The Politics of Supporting Low-Wage Workers,” chapter 21 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

### Recommended Readings

- Gundersen, Craig. “Food Assistance Programs and Food Security,” chapter 22 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

## 10/5 – Week 7: The Safety Net, Part 2 — Housing, Income, and Medicaid

### Readings

- Howard, *Who Cares*, chapters 5–7: “Income”; “Food”; “Housing” (Pollak)
- Grogan, Colleen M. and Christina M. Andrews. “Medicaid,” chapter 19 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

### Assignments

- **Graduate Research Proposals due Monday October 5** (1–2 pages). Topic may be revised through the Week 14 outline milestone—scope feedback is the priority at this stage.

### PapyrusAI module

- **Research Paper Coach** (grad) unlocks after proposal submission. Argues back against your thesis, probes evidence, and pushes you to articulate counterarguments. Will not draft paragraphs.

## 10/12 – Week 8: Midterm Review and Midterm Exam

Monday October 12: midterm review. Wednesday October 14: **MIDTERM EXAM** (in-class).

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### PART III: Case Studies in Reform

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## 10/19 – Week 9: ASYNC — Welfare Reform

No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, October 23. Canvas response due Friday 11:59 p.m.

### Core Readings

- Campbell, chapters 4–5
- Beland, Daniel and Alex Waddan. 2012. “Welfare Reform,” chapter 2 in *The Politics of Policy Change*
- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section IV: “Does Welfare Work?” pp. 116–145 (Pollak)

### Recommended Readings

- Semuels, Alana. 2016. “The End of Welfare as We Know It.” *The Atlantic*
- Rector, Robert, Jamie Hall, and Leslie Ford. 2022. “A Road Map for Conservative, Pro-Family Welfare Reform.” Heritage Foundation

### Grad Extension Readings

- Soss, Joe and Sanford F. Schram. 2007. “A Public Transformed? Welfare Reform as Policy Feedback.” *APSR* 101(1)

### Film

- *Two American Families* (PBS Frontline, 2013, 60 min.)  
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/two-american-families/>



## PapyrusAI module

- **Documentary Companion (Async II).** Pairs the film with Campbell ch. 4–5 and Beland & Waddan on welfare reform; helps you bridge family-level narrative to policy-feedback analysis.

## 10/26 – Week 10: Health Care Reform and the ACA

### Readings

- Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. *Healthcare Reform and American Politics*, chapters 1–4 (Pollak)
- Hacker, Jacob. 2010. “The Road to Somewhere: Why Health Reform Happened.” *Perspectives on Politics* 8(3): 861–876

### Assignments

- **Policy Briefs due Wednesday October 28 (undergraduates)**

## PapyrusAI module

- **Term Paper Dialectical Partner** (undergrad) unlocks after the brief is submitted. Argues back against your thesis, asks for evidence on each claim, and challenges counterarguments. Will not draft paragraphs.

## 11/2 – Week 11: Documentary Screening and Synthesis Discussion

*This week steps back from the reading cycle for structured documentary discussion and synthesis across Parts I–III. Review your notes before class.*

### Film (in-class or assigned in advance)

- *Poverty, Politics and Profit* (PBS Frontline, 2017, 54 min.)  
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/poverty-politics-and-profit/>

## Assignments

- Discussion paper prompt 4 posted this week (tied to welfare reform and ACA units)

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## PART IV: Political Forces Shaping the Welfare State

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### 11/9 – Week 12: Race and the Welfare State, Part 1

*Monday November 9 only — November 11 is Veterans Day; no class.*

#### Readings

- Howard, chapter 9: “Race Still Matters”
- Gilens, Martin. 1999. *Why Americans Hate Welfare*, chapter 5: “The News Media and the Racialization of Poverty” (posted on Canvas)

### 11/16 – Week 13: Race Part 2 and Gender and the Welfare State

#### Core Readings

- Michener, Jamil. 2020. “Race, Politics and the Affordable Care Act.” *Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law* 45(4): 547–566
- Mettler, Suzanne. 2018. *Dividing Citizens: Gender and Federalism in New Deal Public Policy*, chapters 1, 5–6 (Pollak, electronic edition)

#### Recommended Readings

- Morgan, Kimberly J. 2013. “Policies for Work/Life Balance in the United States.” *Informations Sociales* 177: 60–71
- Gornick, Janet C. and Natascia Boeri. “Gender and Poverty,” chapter 10 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

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**Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27. No class.**

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## **11/30 – Week 14: ASYNC — Public Opinion and Interest Groups**

*No in-person meetings. Canvas response due Friday December 4, 11:59 p.m.*

### **Readings**

- Howard, chapter 6: “Shaq is Still Pretty Tall: Public Support for the American Welfare State”
- Howard, chapter 7: “The World According to AARP”
- Desmond, chapter 6: “How We Buy Opportunity”
- Howard, *Who Cares*: “Business and Labor” (Pollak)

### **Assignments**

- **Term Papers due Wednesday December 2 (undergraduates)**
- **Graduate Introductions, Outlines, and Annotated Bibliographies due Wednesday December 2**

### **PapyrusAI module**

- **Public Opinion & Interest Groups (Async III).** Module ties Howard chs. 6–7 and Desmond ch. 6 to your paper topic, helping you locate the political-forces dimension in your own argument before submission.

## **12/7 – Week 15: Solutions and Course Synthesis**

### **Core Readings**

- Campbell, chapter 6: “The Future of America’s Means-Tested Programs”
- Desmond, chapters 7–8

## **Recommended Readings**

- Desmond, chapters 9–10
- Piven, Frances Fox and Lorraine C. Minnite. “Poor People’s Politics,” chapter 33 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

## **Assignments**

- Wednesday December 9: Final exam review

## **12/14 – Week 16: Finals Week**

### **Deliverables**

- **Final Exam:** Date and time assigned by Registrar (December 14–18)
- **Graduate Final Research Papers due:** Same date as Final Exam